

Boulenger 1933

La Doctrine Catholique — Le dogme, les faits dogmatiques, la foi ecclésiastique, les censures (*Catholic Doctrine — Dogma, dogmatic facts, ecclesiastical faith, the censures*)

by Abbé A. Boulenger, honorary canon of Arras; manual first issued with imprimatur of 1917, this printing under Pius XI (c. 1933)

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- *French text from the Internet Archive microform scan of La Doctrine Catholique: Manuel d’instruction religieuse à l’usage des Maisons d’éducation et des Catéchistes volontaires (obvious OCR slips corrected against the page images).*
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Note on this selection: a witness from the ordinary religious-instruction literature of the early twentieth century — valuable precisely because it is a popular manual, showing what was taught as common doctrine. Three texts: (1) the definition of dogmatic facts, with “that such a pope was regularly elected” among the stock examples, and the statement that such truths “impose themselves on our belief as guaranteed by the infallible teaching of the Church” though they are not dogmas; (2) the assignment of dogmatic facts and theological conclusions to “ecclesiastical faith” (the Lennerz–Salaverri wing of the twentieth-century dispute documented in this repository, as against the divine-faith position of Marín-Sola and Fidel García Martínez); (3) the table of doctrinal censures, in which “the pope is not infallible” is graded heretical (contrary to a defined dogma) while “Pius XI is not the legitimate pope” is graded erroneous — contrary to “a certain truth, though not defined.” Under the distinction this repository observes: the infallible certainty of the reigning pope’s legitimacy (the fact) is affirmed as common teaching; the theological note assigned is certain-but-undefined, its denial

censured as error, not heresy — the manualized descendant of the seventeenth-century fact/note settlement (cf. the 1602 Báñez, 1631 Castro Palao, and 1601 Alcalá Theses entries).

Dogma — Truths which are not dogmas: theological conclusions and dogmatic facts (pp. 13–16)

3rd Corollary. — TRUTHS WHICH ARE NOT DOGMAS. — One must therefore not rank among dogmas, because of the absence of one of the required conditions: a) truths whose revelation appears certain but which have not been defined by the Church: for example, the Assumption of the Blessed Virgin; b) truths not revealed and yet taught by the Church, because she judges them useful for the explanation or the defense of revealed truths: such are theological conclusions and dogmatic facts. A theological conclusion is a proposition deduced from two others, of which one is a revealed truth and the other a truth known by reason. For example, if I say, on the one hand, that “God will render to each according to his works” (revealed truth) and, on the other, that God can reward or punish man only if He has given him the freedom to do good or evil (truth of reason), I may conclude that man is free. The existence of human freedom is thus a theological conclusion. Note that certain theological conclusions are contained implicitly in the deposit of Revelation and have therefore been able to be defined by the Church as articles of faith: such is precisely the case of human freedom, which was defined by the Council of Trent, sess. VI, can. 5.

By “dogmatic fact” must be understood every fact which, without being revealed, is in so close a connection with revealed dogma that to deny it is at the same stroke to shake the foundations of the dogma itself. To say, for example, that such an ecumenical council is legitimate, that such a pope was regularly elected, that such a version of Holy Scripture (e.g. the Vulgate) is substantially conformed to the original text, that such an heretical doctrine is contained in such a book: these are so many dogmatic facts. Although theological conclusions and dogmatic facts impose themselves upon our belief as guaranteed by the infallible teaching of the Church, these truths are not dogmas.

Faith — Catholic faith and ecclesiastical faith (p. 163)

In order that a truth be of catholic faith, the proposition of the Church is a necessary condition. Catholic faith therefore comprises all the dogmas proposed to our belief by the infallible authority of the Church — that is, all the truths defined *ex cathedra* by the popes, and all the truths taught as revealed by the magisterium of the Church.

Theologians distinguish in addition ecclesiastical faith. This has for its object the judgments of the Church bearing upon truths which, without belonging to Revelation, are connected with revealed truths and consequently subject to the ecclesiastical magisterium: such are dogmatic facts and theological conclusions (see nn. 16 and 133, first fascicle).

Conclusions. — From the foregoing, the following conclusions may be drawn: 1. The object of divine faith has a wider domain than the object of catholic faith. Catholic faith is always divine faith, but not every truth of divine faith is, by that fact, a truth of catholic faith.

Faith — Doctrinal censures (pp. 169–170)

Doctrinal censures. — A doctrinal censure is a judgment passed by the Church upon a doctrine more or less opposed to a truth defined or regarded as certain. A proposition is called:

1. heretical, when it is opposed to a dogma, that is, to a defined truth: to say, for example, that the pope is not infallible;
2. proximate to heresy, when it is opposed to a doctrine proximate to the faith, that is, to a truth which all theologians hold to be revealed without its being as yet defined: for example, the Immaculate Conception before the definition of Pius IX in 1854;
3. suspect of heresy, when it is equivocal and can be understood in the catholic sense and in the heretical sense, the latter sense however being the more current: to say, for example, that “faith justifies,” an expression generally understood in the Protestant sense;
4. erroneous, when it is opposed to a certain truth, though not defined: to say, for example, that Pius XI is not the legitimate pope;
5. temerarious, when it is opposed to commonly received doctrine: to say, for example, that the Blessed Virgin was not the only woman to have been exempt from original sin.